Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

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Summary. Sets out hybrid and fully remote work rules at Northstar Systems, including default in-office days, anchor days, approval of remote roles, allowances, out-of-city work limits, security and equipment requirements, meeting etiquette, and how to request exceptions or end an arrangement.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy explains how Northstar Systems Private Limited organises hybrid and remote work. It aims to keep teams connected and customers well served while giving employees reasonable flexibility. It applies to all employees from Band B1 to B7 in Bengaluru (Whitefield), Mumbai (Powai) and remote locations. It does not apply to contractors, whose arrangements are set in their contracts, and it does not change the leave and attendance rules in HR-001. Any legal reference is illustrative and to be verified by Legal before external use.

Version 1.0 of this policy consolidates earlier informal practices into one document. Where a team has a customer or operational need that requires a different pattern, section 9 describes how to request an exception.

2. Definitions

- **Hybrid work**: working part of the week from a Northstar office and part from home or another approved location in the registered city.
- **Fully remote**: a role approved to work without a regular in-office pattern, from the employee's registered home location.
- **Registered city**: the city recorded in NorthPeople as the employee's work location, for example Bengaluru, Mumbai or a remote employee's home city.
- **Anchor days**: Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday, the days on which hybrid teams are expected to be in the office together.
- **Core collaboration hours**: 11:00 to 16:00 IST, when employees should be available for meetings.
- **Out-of-city work**: working from a location other than the registered city.
- **Approved workspace**: a home or other location with a safe, private space, reliable internet and the ability to meet the security requirements below.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Employee**: follows the hybrid pattern, keeps availability during core hours, protects company information and keeps the registered city updated in NorthPeople.
- **Reporting manager**: agrees the in-office schedule with the team, ensures coverage and fairness, and raises concerns early.
- **VP of the function**: approves fully remote roles together with the Chief People Officer.
- **Chief People Officer**: co-approves fully remote roles and owns this policy.
- **HR Business Partner**: advises on eligibility, out-of-city requests and allowance claims.
- **Security Desk and IT Service Desk**: approve security aspects of out-of-city work, support remote devices and VPN access.
- **Finance**: processes the work-from-home allowance and home-office setup reimbursement through NorthPay.

4. Hybrid Work

4.1 Default pattern

The default arrangement for all employees whose roles can be performed partly from home is hybrid, with 3 days in the office per week. The anchor days are Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday. Employees should be in the office on anchor days unless on approved leave, travelling for work or attending a customer site. The remaining in-office day is chosen with the manager, preferably on Monday or Friday for team rituals, or as the team agrees.

4.2 Why anchor days

Anchor days make sure that workshops, design reviews, onboarding sessions and cross-functional meetings can happen in person without scheduling difficulty. The Change Advisory Board and the Architecture Review Board, for instance, hold their meetings on days that match this pattern. Managers should avoid scheduling optional team events on non-anchor days so that no one is left out.

4.3 Flexibility within the pattern

A manager may approve swapping an anchor day with another day in the same week for a good reason, for example a medical appointment or a customer visit, provided the team keeps at least two shared anchor days that week. Repeated swaps should be discussed with the HR Business Partner. A team that is mostly distributed, such as a squad with members in both cities, may agree a different set of shared days with the VP of the function; the arrangement must still total 3 office days per employee.

4.4 Hybrid in practice

Example: Rahul (Band B3, Engineering, Bengaluru) works in the office on Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday and from home on Monday and Friday. In a week with a company holiday on Wednesday, he may agree with his manager to attend on Monday as the third day. If his manager approves it in NorthPeople, the week still counts as 3 office days.

5. Fully Remote Roles

5.1 Eligibility

A fully remote role is an exception to the hybrid default and must be approved by both the VP of the function and the Chief People Officer. Approval is considered where the role does not depend on physical presence, the employee has a suitable approved workspace, and the business can support the employee with onboarding and collaboration. About 50 of Northstar's employees work remotely across India. Customer-facing roles that require frequent on-site presence or access to lab equipment are less likely to qualify.

5.2 How to request

1 The employee discusses the request with the reporting manager.
2 The manager submits the request to the HR Business Partner with a business case covering role, location, time zone overlap with core hours, and any cost.
3 The VP of the function reviews and approves or declines.
4 The Chief People Officer gives the second approval.
5 People Team records the arrangement in NorthPeople and informs Security and Finance.

Approval is recorded for a specific role and location. A change of role or home location needs a fresh review.

5.3 Allowances for fully remote employees

Fully remote employees receive a work-from-home allowance of INR 1,500 per month to cover internet and utilities. It is paid through NorthPay with the monthly payroll and does not need receipts. A one-time home-office setup reimbursement of up to INR 15,000 (for example a desk, chair or monitor stand) may be claimed once every 3 years, with receipts, within the claim windows set in HR-004. Hybrid employees are not eligible for the monthly allowance or the setup reimbursement.

Example: Anita (Band B4, Customer Success, fully remote in Jaipur) buys an ergonomic chair for INR 9,800 and a desk lamp for INR 1,500 and files both receipts in NorthPay. The total of INR 11,300 is under the INR 15,000 cap and is reimbursed. Her next setup claim will be possible after 3 years. If she had also bought a monitor arm for INR 5,000, only INR 3,700 of that would be reimbursable since the cap would be reached.

5.4 Obligations of remote employees

Remote employees should be reachable in core collaboration hours, attend key meetings, and travel to Bengaluru or Mumbai for team gatherings, appraisals or onboarding as the manager reasonably requests. Reasonable travel costs for such trips are reimbursed under HR-004 with prior approval in NorthPay.

6. Working from a Different Location

6.1 Rule

Working from a location other than the registered city for more than 10 working days in a year needs HR and Security approval. Days are counted cumulatively per calendar year. Up to 10 working days a year do not need formal approval but the employee must inform the manager and record the location in NorthPeople.

6.2 What approval considers

HR reviews employment-law, tax and payroll implications and the impact on the team. Security reviews the network and physical security of the proposed location, the type of data the employee

handles, and whether the work involves Confidential or Restricted data. Work from outside India is not allowed under this policy unless approved separately by HR, Security and Legal.

6.3 Worked example

Example: Vikram (Band B5, Engineering, Bengaluru) wishes to work from his family home in Kochi for 4 weeks (20 working days) to care for a relative. Because 20 days exceeds 10 working days, he submits a request via his manager to the HR Business Partner and the Security Desk. Security checks that he will use his company laptop with NorthGuard and NorthTunnel, a private workspace and a home network protected as per section 7. HR reviews tax and payroll. If approved, the approval is recorded in NorthPeople. If he had planned only 8 days, no formal approval would be needed, although his manager would be informed.

6.4 Hybrid employees relocating

An employee who permanently moves city must request a change of registered city. Approval depends on business need, and may change allowances, the hybrid pattern and payroll arrangements.

7. Security and Equipment

7.1 Devices and access

Only company laptops may be used for company work; personal laptops are not permitted. Full-disk encryption is mandatory and is monitored by NorthGuard. The screen must lock after 5 minutes of inactivity. All internal applications are reached through the NorthTunnel VPN with multi-factor authentication via NorthID. Passwords must be stored in NorthVault. Operating-system patches must be applied within 14 days of release, so remote employees should restart their laptops when prompted.

7.2 Working in public and shared spaces

Employees should avoid working on Confidential or Restricted material in cafes, co-working spaces or on public Wi-Fi, and must use NorthTunnel at all times outside the office. Screens should not be visible to others, and calls discussing customer or financial data must be taken in private. Smart speakers and personal assistants should be switched off during confidential calls. Printing of company documents at home is discouraged and any printed confidential material must be shredded.

7.3 Data handling

Restricted data such as customer production data, employee personal data, credentials and unreleased financials must be handled only on company devices and approved tools. It must not be sent through personal email or entered into external AI tools. USB mass storage is blocked by default.

7.4 Lost or stolen equipment

If a laptop or phone is lost or stolen, the employee must report it to the Security Desk within 1 hour of discovery (ext. 5555 or security@northstar-systems.example) and to the IT Service Desk within 24 hours. Remote wipe is carried out within 4 hours of confirmed loss. See SEC-004 and SEC-009 for device and acceptable use requirements.

7.5 Equipment support

Standard laptops are refreshed every 48 months. Remote employees raise hardware faults through NorthDesk and may receive a replacement by courier. Damaged equipment must be reported within 24 hours. Equipment remains company property, carries an asset tag, and must be returned at exit as described in HR-006.

8. Collaboration Norms

- Keep your calendar current and mark working location (office, home, travelling) in NorthPeople.
- Schedule meetings inside core collaboration hours of 11:00 to 16:00 IST; avoid requiring attendance outside the 9:30 to 18:30 working day.
- Use video for team meetings where practical, and share written notes and decisions afterwards.
- Respond to urgent messages within a reasonable time during your working day; on-call arrangements for production are governed by Engineering policies, not by this document.
- On anchor days, hold cross-team workshops, onboarding sessions and performance conversations in person where possible.
- Respect time zones and holiday calendars for colleagues in other locations.

Remote and hybrid employees are held to the same performance standards as office-based colleagues. Managers must base assessments on outcomes and behaviours, not on visibility or hours online, and calibration under HR-002 applies equally to all.

8.1 Customer-facing and on-call roles

Customer Success and Support employees working in hybrid mode must keep their shift roster and support-tier coverage intact. Standard-tier support runs 9:00 to 19:00 IST Monday to Friday, and Premier and Enterprise P1 and P2 coverage is 24x7, so managers must publish rosters that show who is in the office and who is remote on each anchor day. An engineer who is on call from home must have a stable connection, a charged phone and laptop, and access to NorthTunnel and NorthWatch, and should tell the manager if the home connection fails so that the page can be routed to the secondary engineer.

8.2 Onboarding and offboarding while remote

New joiners should spend their first week in the office where practical so that equipment, badge, security training and introductions happen in person; fully remote joiners receive their laptop by courier and complete onboarding tasks in NorthPeople with a buddy. Remote leavers must return all equipment by courier within 5 working days of the last working day, and their access ends by 18:30 IST on the last working day as set out in HR-006.

8.3 Common questions on counting days

Days on approved leave, company holidays, business travel and customer-site visits do not count against the 3-day office pattern for that week. A half-day in the office counts as half a day. If an employee is in the office only 2 days in a week for a non-approved reason, the manager should discuss it and may record it as a pattern deviation; repeated deviation can be reviewed under the performance process.

9. Exceptions, Review and Ending an Arrangement

9.1 Exceptions

Teams or individuals who need a different hybrid pattern, for example because of a medical condition, a caregiving need, or a customer requirement, may request an exception from the

reporting manager. The HR Business Partner and the VP of the function must approve exceptions that last longer than one month. Temporary exceptions should have an end date recorded in NorthPeople.

9.2 Review and withdrawal

A fully remote arrangement is reviewed annually by the manager and HR Business Partner. The company may withdraw or change an arrangement with at least 30 days' written notice where the business need changes, where performance concerns arise that are linked to the arrangement, or where security requirements are not met. Serious security breaches may lead to immediate suspension of remote access. The employee may raise concerns through the grievance route in HR-002.

9.3 Moving between hybrid and fully remote

An employee moving from fully remote to hybrid stops receiving the work-from-home allowance from the month after the change. An employee moving from hybrid to fully remote starts the allowance in the month after approval. The home-office setup reimbursement is still limited to once every 3 years from the date of the last claim.

9.4 Business continuity

In a business continuity event, such as Bengaluru headquarters becoming unavailable, all Bengaluru staff work remotely within 4 hours and critical teams operate from Mumbai. Employees should keep their laptops, VPN access and contact details ready at all times, and managers should confirm that their teams know the communication tree. Hybrid employees do not need separate approval to work from home during such an event.

10. Frequently Asked Questions

Are all three anchor days mandatory? Hybrid employees are expected in the office on Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday unless on leave, travel or with an approved swap.

Do hybrid employees receive the INR 1,500 monthly allowance? No. It is paid only to approved fully remote employees.

How many days can I work from another city without approval? Up to 10 working days in a year; beyond that you need HR and Security approval.

Can I use my personal laptop at home? No. Only company laptops may be used for company work.

Who approves a new fully remote role? The VP of the function and the Chief People Officer.

11. Related Documents

- HR-001 sets leave, attendance and working hours.
- SEC-004 and SEC-009 set device, access and acceptable-use requirements for remote work.
- OPS-007 covers office facilities, badge access and equipment logistics.
- HR-004 covers expense claims for remote-work travel and setup reimbursement claims.

12. Revision History

Version	Date	Change	Approved by
1.0	2025-08-15	First issue consolidating hybrid and remote practice	Chief People Officer